enter the café and followed. Whoever had told her to come this way knew what he was doing. She stepped outside and walked briskly away.

Trying to appear calm, though her pulse raced and her nerve endings buzzed, she strode on. There was still a chance she might run into the soldier. Rose hadn't been this frightened since that terrible day two years ago when the French army blew up all the bridges in a desperate attempt to prevent the Germans from crossing the Loire and advancing deeper into France. The memory remained etched in her mind like one of her drawings —dive bombers screeching overhead as she and Léa raced to the bunker below the Dessaux vinegar factory, where they huddled underground, fires raging above. After ten long hours, they emerged to a new world: German soldiers patrolled streets of rubble and dust while fires burned for three more days. In an instant, their old life had disappeared.

The farther Rose walked, the more her thoughts drifted back to the man who had guided her to the safety of the café. Léa constantly drilled into her head that since the Occupation, trickery and deception had become part of daily life, what everyone called System D for *se débrouiller*, or getting by no matter the cost to others. Any sense of *fraternité* was lost.

And yet, someone *had* helped her. She wished she could thank him, but she'd been running too fast, all the faces she passed a blur. Now there was no way to find him, just like there was no way to retrieve the sketchbook that meant everything to her. She froze. The sketchbook had her name and address written on the back. If the soldier found it, he could track her to Madame Martin's boardinghouse, where she and Léa shared a room. Rose considered returning to the quai to look for it, but if the soldier was still there, he'd see her. She couldn't risk it.

* * *

As Léa undid her braids later that evening, Rose sat on the bed and told her what had happened at the quai.

"How could you not see the sign?" Léa brushed Rose's long brown hair. "You should be more—"

"I was there every day this week, and there wasn't a sign, or at least I don't think so . . ."

Léa put the brush down. "You were lucky. Be careful and stay out of